



Leading Through the Enrollment Cliff of 2026 (Part I)

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In higher education, we are all familiar with this formula: enrollment = funding = operating capital. While that does always hold true in our public institutions, is it perhaps time to redirect to a formula something like this: strategic recruitment efforts = enrollment = operating capital, due to the looming enrollment cliff.

I recently attended a presentation at my institution where participants were reminded, “YOU are the U in ECU.” We all matter to our institution’s future. That not only reminded me of the consequences of the Great Recession of 2008, it forced me to consider its impacts on our public college institutions 18 years later. Because of the recession, birth rates in the U.S. were lower in 2008; the consequence of that is there will be fewer college-aged young adults in 2026. Which also means the employee pool beginning in 2030 will also be negatively affected.

The PEW Research Center (Fig. 1) provides this timeline of births compared to economic prosperity, downturn, and recession in the U.S.

College Selection Variables

How does a college-age student make their decision about which college to attend? Throughout my career in higher education I have heard freshman and transfer students state that they made their college choice based on the following: (*please note these are in no particular order*)

- Legacy decision – following family members
- Cost/Tuition

- Accepted by the institution
- They “felt good” when they visited (huge impact in my part of the country)
- Academic programs/Desired Major offered
- Institutional reputation

Of course, *many* more reasons drive a college decision choice, but all evidence points to our institutions considering each aspect now and devising a plan that will allow us to keep our doors open. While we can thank the recession of 2008 for this cliff; if we are strategic, we have already begun to examine and improve our recruiting practices which will allow our educational systems to continue to educate. Demand forecasts and demographic analyses will prove useful as we plan for the enrollment cliff.

Below are the projected growth and declines throughout the country (Fig. 2).

Positive Impacts for Regional Institutions

Published in *The Hechinger Report* (Barshay 2018) and in Kline’s column (2019), Nathan Grawe suggested that regional institutions have more to lose as the enrollment cliff begins than do elite institutions. In fact, while regional institutions are to see a decline in enrollment, elite institutions are predicted to see an increase. This finding is based on institutional reputation and student-demographic of those institutions.

Knowing who you serve is critical. Spending time identifying characteristics of your student population will impact your ability to recruit. At my institution, for example, we *know* that 55% of our fall cohorts over the last several years have been first generation college students (neither parent has a four-year college degree). Information like this will assist us in developing admissions protocols in order to continue to recruit and educate this group of students. It does also mean, however, that we will need to continue to evaluate our

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Fertility Often Rises and Falls with Economic Cycles

Annual number of births per 1,000 women of childbearing age



Note: 2012 data are preliminary.

Sources: Statistics calculated using data obtained from U.S. Census Bureau, National Center for Health Statistics and Heuser, Robert L. *Fertility tables for birth cohorts by color*. U.S. Department of Health, Education, and Welfare. DHEW Publication No. (HRA)76-1152

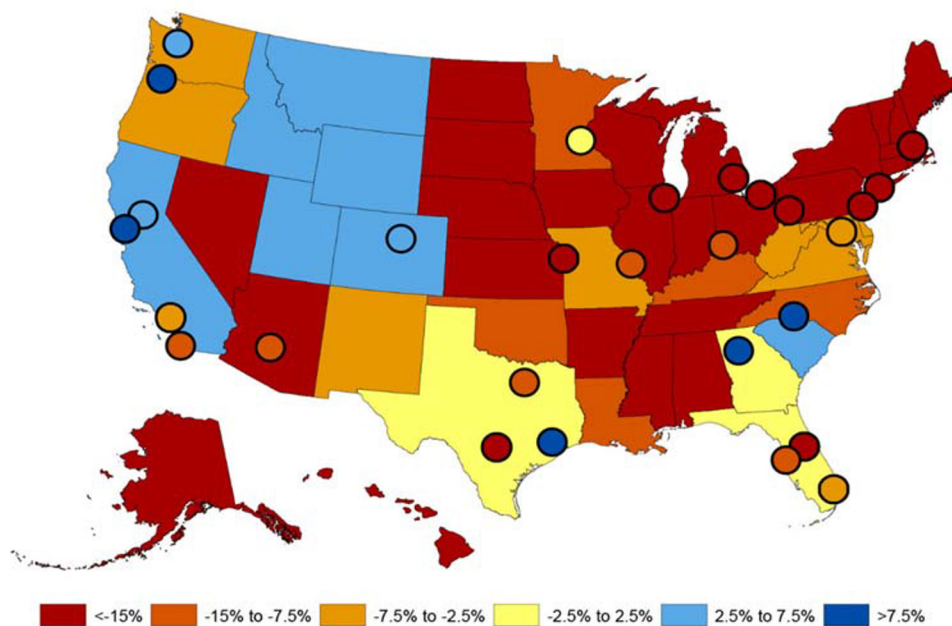
PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Fig. 1 Fertility Often Rises and Falls with Economic Cycles. Note: 2012 data are preliminary. Sources: Statistics calculated using data obtained from U.S. Census Bureau, National Center for Health Statistics and Heuser, Robert L.

Fertility tables for birth cohorts by color. U.S. Department of Health, Education, and Welfare. DHEW Publication No. (HRA)76-1152. (Livingston and Cohn 2013).

Fig. 2 Forecasted growth and decline in college-going students, 2012–2019. Source: Reproduced with written permission from Nathan D. Grawe. Figure originally appeared in Grawe (2017)

Forecasted growth and decline in college-going students, 2012–2029



Source: Nathan D. Grawe, Carleton College.pdf

approach, methods, and investment in providing resources and support to them once they are on campus.

With as much evidence as we have informing us about the declining population, we need to get busy pulling our institution's data and using it to inform changes in practices immediately. Leading faculty and staff through this unknown environment is going to be challenging—the uncertainty will bring fear and reaction. We need to remember, we are well-versed in the principles of collecting, analyzing, and interpreting data and *responding* to conditions.

Part II Will Focus on Specific Strategies and Elements of Leadership Needed to Successfully Navigate the Enrollment Cliff

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